Knowledge Cutoff Effects on LLM-Generated Literature Reviews in Rapidly Evolving Fields

AMAN TIWARI, Indian Institute of Information Technology, India

Large language models (LLMs) are increasingly used to support literature discovery, synthesis, summarization, and the preparation of research reviews. Their usefulness, however, is constrained by a fundamental temporal asymmetry: scientific knowledge evolves continuously, whereas a conventional pretrained model acquires most of its parametric knowledge from a finite historical training corpus. This temporal mismatch is particularly consequential in rapidly evolving fields such as artificial intelligence, biomedicine, climate science, cybersecurity, and emerging technologies, where important findings, terminology, datasets, methods, and consensus positions may change substantially within months. This review examines how knowledge cutoffs affect LLM-generated literature reviews and argues that the problem extends beyond simple omission of recent papers. Cutoffs can distort literature coverage, citation selection, interpretation of research trends, assessment of methodological consensus, and identification of research gaps. The review synthesizes research on temporal knowledge, retrieval-augmented generation (RAG), continual learning, knowledge editing, hallucination, citation reliability, and automated scientific literature synthesis. Current approaches—including scholarly retrieval, temporal filtering, continual updating, model editing, agentic research systems, and citation verification—reduce some cutoff effects but do not eliminate temporal misalignment. The central research gap is the lack of evaluation that treats time as a first-class property of scholarly evidence. Future systems therefore require timestamp-aware retrieval, source provenance, temporal reasoning, claim-level citation verification, uncertainty estimation, conflict resolution, and reproducible search logs.

CCS Concepts: • **Computing methodologies** → **Natural language processing**; • **Information systems** → **Digital libraries and archives**.

Additional Key Words and Phrases: large language models, knowledge cutoff, literature review, scientific literature synthesis, temporal knowledge, retrieval-augmented generation, citation reliability, continual learning, research agents, temporal alignment

1 Introduction

Literature reviews organize existing evidence, identify methodological developments, expose disagreements, and establish the rationale for new investigations. Traditionally, preparing a high-quality review requires iterative database searching, screening, reading, comparison, citation management, and expert synthesis. The growth of scientific publication has made this process increasingly difficult for individual researchers. Recent work on automated literature research explicitly identifies publication volume as a major bottleneck and motivates LLM-based review-generation systems as a way of reducing the associated cognitive burden [16].

LLMs have changed this workflow by allowing researchers to ask questions in natural language and receive summaries, comparisons, explanations, and draft reviews. However, conventional LLMs are not continuously synchronized with the scholarly record. Their parametric knowledge is primarily acquired during pretraining, and a model with a training cutoff cannot inherently know papers, discoveries, terminology, or empirical results that emerged afterward. Retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) addresses part of this limitation by combining parametric model knowledge with an external non-parametric memory that can be updated independently of model weights [10].

The knowledge-cutoff problem is more complicated than asking whether an LLM "knows" a recent paper. Cheng et al. show that the effective cutoff of an LLM can differ from its nominally reported cutoff because training corpora contain documents with different temporal properties [3]. Older material can remain present in later web crawls, while

Author's Contact Information: Aman Tiwari, Indian Institute of Information Technology, India.

deduplication and corpus construction can create additional temporal inconsistencies. Thus, model knowledge is better understood as a temporal distribution than as a single date.

For literature reviews, this distinction is particularly important. A review is not merely a collection of facts; it is a structured representation of how a field has developed. If an LLM misses recent studies, it can misrepresent the current state of evidence, incorrectly identify an old problem as unsolved, fail to recognize a newly established method, overstate the importance of obsolete techniques, or describe a historical research debate as if it were current. Knowledge-cutoff effects can therefore become epistemic distortions rather than ordinary factual errors.

This paper addresses five questions:

(1) How do knowledge cutoffs influence LLM-generated literature reviews?
(2) Why are rapidly evolving fields especially vulnerable?
(3) Which technical approaches mitigate temporal limitations?
(4) What new failure modes arise when retrieval and agentic systems are introduced?
(5) What evaluation and architectural principles are required for temporally reliable review systems?

The paper is a conceptual and narrative synthesis of scholarly research available through August 2026. It does not claim to be a systematic review of every publication on LLM-assisted literature review. Instead, it integrates research from temporal reasoning, RAG, continual learning, scientific literature synthesis, hallucination, citation verification, and research-agent evaluation. Section 2 establishes the conceptual foundations, Section 3 analyzes the distortions caused by temporal misalignment, and Section 4 compares mitigation approaches.

2 Background and Related Work

2.1 Parametric knowledge and the knowledge cutoff

Modern LLMs store statistical representations of language and world knowledge in their parameters. This design provides broad generalization capabilities but creates a separation between model knowledge and current external knowledge. RAG formalizes a complementary relationship between parametric and non-parametric memory [10].

A nominal knowledge cutoff is therefore best understood as an approximation to the latest point in time represented by the training distribution. Cheng et al. demonstrate that the effective boundary can vary by source and topic [3]. A model may have detailed knowledge of an older research area while having little representation of a newly emerging subfield. Conversely, some newer facts may occur in its training distribution even when its nominal cutoff is earlier.

2.2 Temporal knowledge and evolving facts

Temporal knowledge has become an active research problem. Kim et al. evaluate world knowledge in lifelong language models and show difficulties associated with evolving information [8]. Zhang and Choi frame the issue as temporal misalignment: a model trained on historical data may be asked questions about the present. Their fact-duration approach estimates how long facts are likely to remain valid and uses that information to reduce the impact of stale knowledge [19].

More recent benchmarks extend evaluation beyond static factual recall. EvolveBench evaluates temporal competence through dimensions including temporal awareness, trustworthiness, understanding, and reasoning, while HoH examines the effect of outdated information in retrieval-based settings [13, 20]. These results indicate that temporal reliability cannot be reduced to model size or general reasoning ability. A model may reason well while still failing to determine whether a claim is valid at the requested point in time.

2.3 Hallucination and citation reliability

Knowledge cutoffs interact with hallucination. When a model cannot retrieve a recent paper, it may generate a plausible but unsupported description of what the literature contains. More generally, LLM-generated text can contain unsupported or factually inconsistent information [7, 12].

The problem is especially important for academic writing because literature reviews require citations. Walters and Wilder evaluated ChatGPT-generated bibliographic citations and documented fabricated and erroneous references [15]. Citation existence and citation validity should therefore be distinguished. A citation may point to a real paper while failing to support the attached claim. Conversely, a genuine older paper may be cited because a newer study is inaccessible, producing a formally valid but temporally incomplete review.

The cutoff problem can consequently be decomposed into three related dimensions:

- **Coverage error:** important recent literature is missing.
- **Temporal attribution error:** a valid source is presented as representing current knowledge when it represents an earlier state.
- **Citation error:** a reference is nonexistent, bibliographically inaccurate, or weakly entailed by the cited source.

2.4 LLMs in literature-review workflows

LLM use in evidence synthesis increasingly extends beyond simple summarization. A scoping review identified applications across 10 of 13 systematic-review stages, with literature search, study selection, and data extraction among the most frequent uses, while fully validated applications remained uncommon [11].

Systems such as LitLLM use search, keyword generation, reranking, and RAG to construct related-work sections [1]. PaperQA demonstrates retrieval across full-text scientific papers for evidence-grounded question answering and synthesis [9]. These systems mark a transition from closed-book generation toward evidence-grounded research assistance, but the evidence itself still requires temporal and bibliographic validation.

3 How Knowledge Cutoffs Distort Literature Reviews

3.1 Incomplete temporal coverage

The most direct consequence of a knowledge cutoff is missing literature. In a rapidly evolving field, papers published after training may contain new benchmark results, limitations, methodologies, datasets, competing approaches, replications, negative findings, or corrections to previously accepted conclusions. Omission is therefore not temporally neutral: missing a recent study can change the direction of a review.

Fluent generation can conceal this incompleteness. A review may appear comprehensive because the prose is coherent even though the evidence base is incomplete. This creates a particularly important scholarly risk: stylistic quality can be mistaken for temporal coverage.

3.2 Citation-lag bias

Scientific influence is not synchronized with publication date. New papers often have few citations, whereas older papers accumulate citations over time. Automated literature systems that use citation counts or citation networks as proxies for importance may therefore favor established literature. Wu et al. explicitly identify citation lag as a challenge for automated review generation in rapidly evolving fields [16].

The resulting review can become "popular-paper-centric" rather than state-of-the-art-centric. Retrieval probability may depend on age, citation count, indexing history, visibility, and textual prominence in addition to topical relevance.

3.3 Stale consensus

A cutoff can preserve an older consensus. Suppose a field historically concluded that Method A was superior to Method B, while later studies show that Method B performs better under realistic conditions. A cutoff-limited LLM may continue to describe Method A as state of the art. This is not necessarily a hallucination: the model may produce a historically accurate statement using genuine sources. The error lies in temporal framing.

The distinction can be expressed as a two-dimensional validity condition:

$$\text{Valid}(c, s, t) = \text{Evidence}(c, s) \times \text{TemporalFit}(s, t), \tag{1}$$

where c is a claim, s is its supporting source, and t is the reference time. Equation (1) illustrates why factual correctness alone is insufficient for a current literature review.

3.4 Distorted research gaps

Identifying research gaps is one of the most valuable functions of a review, but it is highly vulnerable to cutoff effects. A system may state that few studies investigate a problem when several relevant studies were published after its training cutoff. This creates false novelty and can encourage duplicated research. The reverse can also occur: a model may identify a historical gap that recent work has already addressed.

3.5 Misinterpretation of research trends

A literature review should explain what methods dominated earlier research, what changed, why the change occurred, which findings have been replicated, which approaches are emerging, and what remains uncertain. A static LLM is poorly suited to these questions without explicit temporal evidence. Findings from temporal benchmarks reinforce this limitation [8, 20].

3.6 Changing terminology

Rapidly evolving fields frequently change terminology. A cutoff-limited model may fail to recognize a new term, interpret it using an older definition, miss papers because retrieval queries use obsolete terminology, or incorrectly merge historically distinct concepts. The problem is particularly consequential in interdisciplinary areas where terminology evolves faster than indexing systems.

3.7 Conflicting temporal evidence

Adding retrieval does not automatically solve the problem. A retrieval corpus may contain multiple versions of the same information: a preprint, conference paper, journal article, correction, retraction, or later replication. A system must determine not only which source is relevant, but which source is temporally and scientifically authoritative.

HoH demonstrates that outdated information in a retrieval knowledge base can reduce accuracy even when current information is also available [13]. RAG therefore changes the question from "Does the model know the latest information?" to "Can the system retrieve, rank, reconcile, and correctly attribute information according to time?"

4 Current Approaches and Developments

4.1 Retrieval-augmented generation

RAG retrieves external documents and conditions generation on the retrieved evidence [10]. A simplified literature-review pipeline is represented by

$$Q \xrightarrow{R(\cdot,D)} C \xrightarrow{G(\cdot,Q)} A, \tag{2}$$

where Q is the research question, D is the external corpus, R is retrieval, C is retrieved context, and G is generation producing answer or review A. RAG allows the underlying model to remain unchanged while the evidence corpus is updated, but retrieval quality becomes a critical dependency.

4.2 Scholarly RAG

General web search is not necessarily sufficient for scholarly review generation. Scientific systems need metadata, abstracts, full text, publication dates, versions, citations, author information, and persistent identifiers. PaperQA is an early research-oriented example [9]. OpenScholar is a more recent specialized system backed by a large scientific datastore and combines retrieval, reranking, and iterative self-feedback [2]. Its results illustrate that evidence infrastructure and architecture can be as important as model scale for scientific synthesis.

4.3 Temporal filtering and time-aware retrieval

Temporal filtering makes the reference time explicit. For a review describing the state of a field as of 2023, post-2023 evidence should not be used as if it were available at that time. Conversely, a current review should prioritize recent evidence. A time-aware retrieval score can be written as

$$S(d) = \alpha R(d, q) + \beta T(d, t) + \gamma A(d) + \delta C(d), \tag{3}$$

where R is semantic relevance, T is temporal relevance to reference time t, A is source authority, and C is scholarly significance. Equation (3) formalizes the idea that a highly cited but obsolete paper should not automatically outrank a recent and directly relevant study.

4.4 Continual learning

Continual-learning research distinguishes continual pretraining, domain-adaptive pretraining, and continual fine-tuning [14, 17]. The advantage is that new knowledge becomes part of the model's internal representation. Disadvantages include computational cost, catastrophic forgetting, and changing model behavior. For literature-review systems, continual updating also introduces reproducibility problems: two researchers querying the "same" system at different times may obtain different reviews.

4.5 Knowledge editing

Knowledge editing modifies selected model representations rather than retraining the entire model. Yin et al. argue that outdated knowledge should not simply be erased because historical information remains useful for historical questions [18]. Their temporal knowledge-editing formulation emphasizes preserving historical knowledge while integrating new knowledge. This distinction is important for reviews, which should explain the development of a field rather than overwrite its history.

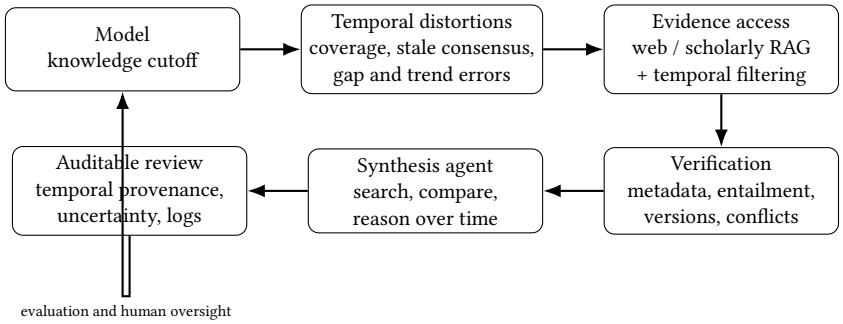


Fig. 1. Taxonomy and workflow for temporally reliable LLM-generated literature reviews. The pipeline separates the source of temporal risk from retrieval, verification, synthesis, and audit stages.

4.6 Fact-duration modeling

Zhang and Choi propose predicting how long facts remain valid and using volatility to determine when external information should be sought [19]. The principle can be extended from facts to scholarly claims: established mathematical results may have low temporal volatility, state-of-the-art benchmark results may have high volatility, and current regulatory guidance may have very high volatility. Retrieval effort can therefore be made proportional to expected temporal volatility.

4.7 Agentic deep research

Research agents can plan searches, execute multiple retrieval steps, compare sources, and generate structured reports. DeepResearch Bench evaluates deep-research agents on PhD-level tasks and emphasizes research and citation quality [5]. Agentic systems can reduce cutoff effects by accessing post-cutoff information, but they also introduce query drift, source-selection bias, retrieval loops, incomplete coverage, premature stopping, inconsistent ranking, opaque decision processes, and temporal contamination.

4.8 Citation verification

Citation verification should occur at multiple levels: existence, metadata, temporal validity, entailment, scope, and completeness. Walters and Wilder demonstrate why bibliographic verification is necessary [15]. Research on citation constraints further motivates explicit controls over the relationship between generated claims and references [4]. Verification should therefore be integrated into the generation pipeline rather than applied only after a review is written.

Figure 1 summarizes the central architectural argument of this review: retrieval alone is not sufficient. Temporal filtering, source-version tracking, claim verification, conflict handling, and human oversight form complementary layers.

Table 1 shows that the approaches address different failure modes. No single method simultaneously guarantees freshness, temporal attribution, evidence completeness, and reproducibility.

Table 1. Comparison of approaches for reducing knowledge-cutoff effects in literature-review systems.

Approach	Freshness mechanism	Primary strength	Residual temporal risk	Reproducibility consideration
RAG [10]	External corpus retrieval	Updates evidence without retraining	Stale or conflicting corpus entries	Store retrieved document IDs and timestamps
Scholarly RAG [2, 9]	Scientific full text and metadata	Better evidence grounding and citation support	Version ambiguity and retrieval bias	Preserve corpus version and ranking
Temporal filtering	Publication-date constraints	Explicit reference-time control	Publication date alone does not establish evidence quality	Record cutoff and filtering rule
Continual learning [14, 17]	Periodic parameter updates	New knowledge becomes internal	Forgetting and continuously changing model behavior	Version every model checkpoint
Knowledge editing [18]	Targeted representation updates	Efficient updates with historical knowledge preservation	Editing may interact with related facts	Record edit operations and model state
Agentic research [5]	Iterative search and synthesis	Multi-step evidence gathering	Query drift, source bias, premature stopping	Log all searches, rankings, and prompts
Citation verification [4, 15]	Claim–reference checking	Detects bibliographic and support errors	Does not guarantee missing literature is found	Preserve verification outputs and evidence

5 Research Challenges and Limitations

5.1 No universal definition of "current"

A review can be current relative to its publication date, the last database search, a specified historical cutoff, the latest peer-reviewed literature, the latest preprints, a field-specific guideline, or a dynamically changing evidence base. Temporal correctness therefore requires an explicit reference time.

5.2 Preprints and publication versions

Rapidly evolving fields often rely heavily on preprints. A paper may exist as a preprint, a conference paper, and later a journal version. A temporally accurate system should represent these as related versions rather than independent pieces of evidence.

5.3 Retractions and corrections

Scientific knowledge is not monotonically additive. New papers can invalidate earlier results through corrections, retractions, failed replications, or improved methodologies. A "latest paper wins" strategy is therefore inadequate. Temporal reasoning must be combined with evidence quality and scientific authority.

5.4 Retrieval bias

RAG systems inherit biases from their retrieval corpus. If a corpus underrepresents journals, languages, geographic regions, disciplines, or publication types, the generated review inherits those gaps. Retrieval can therefore improve freshness without improving representativeness.

5.5 Conflicting evidence

Scientific fields rarely progress through simple replacement. Competing studies may coexist for years. An LLM-generated review may collapse disagreement into a single narrative because generation rewards coherence. This creates a tension between readability and epistemic fidelity.

5.6 Citation correctness versus citation completeness

A review can contain valid citations and still be poor if it omits major recent studies. Evaluation should therefore distinguish citation correctness from evidence coverage. This distinction follows from the broader observation that factuality and faithfulness do not fully capture the quality of scholarly synthesis [12].

5.7 Evaluation benchmarks remain incomplete

EvolveBench and HoH are important steps toward temporal evaluation, but most benchmark designs still focus on questions or individual answers rather than full literature-review generation [13, 20]. A review requires broader evaluation dimensions: search completeness, chronological coverage, citation accuracy, claim-evidence alignment, synthesis quality, disagreement representation, methodological comparison, gap identification, and reproducibility.

5.8 Reproducibility

Dynamic retrieval creates a paradox: a system can become more current while becoming less reproducible. If the same query is executed six months apart, the retrieved literature may differ. Scholarly use therefore requires preservation of query strings, search date, database version, retrieved document IDs, document versions, ranking results, model version, prompts, and generation settings.

Figure 2 makes the reproducibility requirement explicit: the system should retain an auditable chain from the research question and reference time to the evidence and final claims.

6 Research Gaps and Future Directions

6.1 Temporal completeness as a formal evaluation metric

Current evaluation commonly emphasizes factual correctness and citation accuracy. Future literature-review benchmarks should also measure temporal completeness. One possible metric is

$$TC = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^{n} w_i I_i}{\sum_{i=1}^{n} w_i}, \tag{4}$$

where w_i represents the importance of an expected publication or finding and $I_i \in \{0, 1\}$ indicates whether the review represents that item with appropriate temporal context. Equation (4) distinguishes a review that is factually correct but incomplete from one that provides broad current coverage. The metric is a proposed design concept rather than an established benchmark.

6.2 Claim-level temporal provenance

Every substantive claim should ideally have a provenance tuple

$$P = (\text{source}, \text{date}, \text{version}, \text{evidence}, \text{confidence}). \tag{5}$$

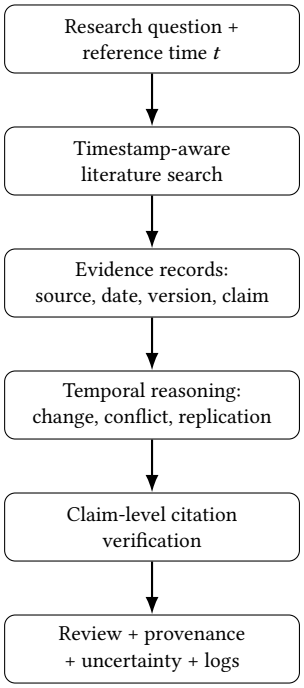


Fig. 2. Proposed temporal evidence lifecycle for a literature-review system. The reference time is established before retrieval and remains explicit through evidence selection, temporal reasoning, citation verification, and final reporting.

This would enable a system to state not simply that a method is effective, but to describe the time window, conditions, evidence strength, and remaining uncertainty. Equation (5) also provides a natural unit for auditing generated reviews.

6.3 Temporal knowledge graphs

Future systems could represent literature as a temporal graph

$$G_T = (V, E, T), \tag{6}$$

where nodes V represent papers, methods, datasets, claims, and findings; edges E represent citations, comparisons, replications, contradictions, and extensions; and T records temporal validity. Such a graph would allow an LLM to reason over changes in relationships rather than merely retrieve documents.

6.4 Temporal conflict resolution

Systems need explicit mechanisms for deciding what to do when sources disagree. A useful evidence hierarchy can consider publication date, peer-review status, methodological quality, replication evidence, retraction/correction status, sample size, domain authority, and directness of evidence. The latest source should not automatically dominate.

6.5 Time-aware research agents

Future research agents should maintain a temporal state during search. Rather than simply accumulating sources, the agent should ask when a claim was established, whether it subsequently changed, whether newer contradictory

Table 2. Proposed evaluation dimensions for temporally reliable literature reviews.

Dimension	Core question
Temporal coverage	Did the system find important recent work?
Citation validity	Do cited papers exist and have correct metadata?
Citation entailment	Does each citation support the attached claim?
Temporal attribution	Is evidence placed in the correct historical context?
Trend fidelity	Does the review accurately describe field evolution?
Conflict representation	Are competing findings represented?
Gap validity	Are claimed gaps actually unresolved?
Reproducibility	Can another researcher reconstruct the review?

evidence exists, whether a paper was available by the requested cutoff, whether it is a preprint or final publication, and whether the result has been replicated. This would transform agents from document collectors into temporal evidence synthesizers.

6.6 Benchmarking literature reviews rather than individual answers

The field needs benchmark suites specifically designed for AI-generated literature reviews. Such benchmarks should contain rapidly changing topics with known publication timelines and expert-created reference reviews. Evaluation should measure the dimensions summarized in Table 2.

6.7 Human-AI collaboration

The evidence supports treating LLMs as research assistants rather than autonomous replacements for scholarly judgment. The scoping review by Lieberum et al. found growing use across systematic-review tasks but limited validation of unrestricted applications [11]. Human researchers remain important for assessing methodological quality, interpreting contradictory findings, judging novelty, identifying disciplinary context, evaluating source credibility, and determining whether a research gap is genuinely meaningful.

6.8 Explicit uncertainty and abstention

An LLM should be able to report that the available evidence is insufficient to establish a consensus rather than generating a confident synthesis from incomplete evidence. Gao et al. show that prompted knowledge cutoffs can simulate temporal restrictions but do not fully prevent leakage from related post-cutoff information [6]. Temporal awareness therefore cannot depend exclusively on prompting; systems need mechanisms for verifying temporal admissibility.

7 Conclusion

Knowledge cutoffs create a fundamental reliability problem for LLM-generated literature reviews in rapidly evolving scientific fields. The problem is not limited to missing recent papers. A static knowledge boundary can influence the perceived state of the field, distort citation patterns, preserve obsolete consensus, generate false research gaps, and misrepresent emerging methodological trends.

The central insight is that scholarly synthesis is inherently temporal. A literature review describes not only what is known, but when it became known, how evidence changed, which findings were superseded, and where uncertainty remains. Conventional LLMs are optimized primarily for language prediction and general reasoning, not for maintaining an auditable temporal model of scientific knowledge.

RAG provides an important architectural response by separating language-generation capabilities from external knowledge storage. Scholarly systems such as PaperQA, LitLLM, automated review-generation pipelines, and OpenScholar demonstrate increasingly sophisticated ways of combining retrieval with LLM-based synthesis [1, 2, 9, 16]. Nevertheless, retrieval introduces its own temporal problems: outdated documents can coexist with current ones, citation networks can privilege older literature, and retrieval systems can fail to distinguish versions or conflicting findings.

Temporal benchmarks reinforce this conclusion. Research on evolving knowledge and outdated retrieval evidence shows that temporal awareness remains an unresolved dimension even for capable systems [8, 13, 20]. Future literature-review systems should therefore treat time as a first-class property of evidence. Reliable systems should combine timestamp-aware scholarly retrieval, temporal provenance, claim-level citation verification, source-version tracking, conflict resolution, uncertainty estimation, and reproducible search logs.

The goal should not be an LLM that merely produces a review that sounds current. It should be a research system that can demonstrate why its review is current, which evidence supports each claim, when that evidence was available, what evidence contradicts it, and what remains unknown. The architecture in Figure 1 and the evaluation dimensions in Table 2 provide a compact representation of this direction.

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